PEAK WELLNESS
CENTERS, PLLC

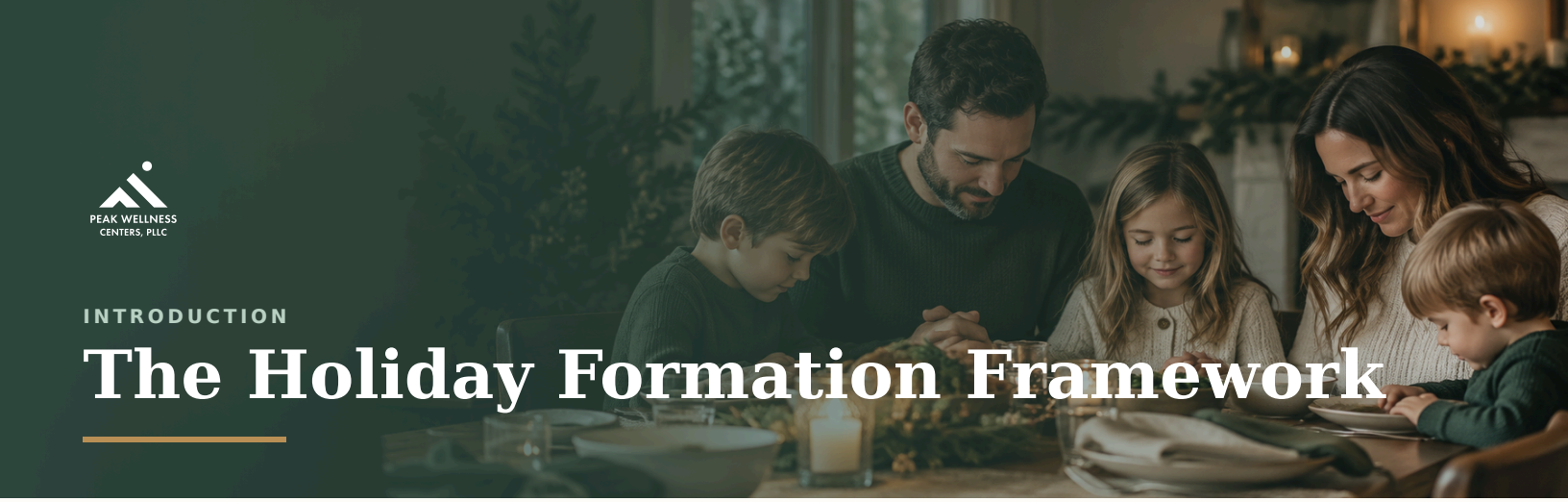
A GOSPEL-CENTERED GUIDE

Thriving the Holidays

Seasonal rhythms, heart reflection, and grace for every age at home.

"Peace I leave with you; my peace I give you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled and do not be afraid."
JOHN 14:27

1	**Early Childhood** AGES 3-4½ | Preschool / Pre-K	*The Commander*
2	**Middle Childhood** AGES 5-7 | Kindergarten - 2nd Grade	*The Coach*
3	**Pre-Adolescence** AGES 8-10 | 3rd - 5th Grade	*The Captain*
4	**Early Adolescence** AGES 11-12 | 6th - 7th Grade	*The Counselor*
5	**High School & Adulthood** AGES 13-18+ | 9th Grade & Beyond	*The Consultant*



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INTRODUCTION

The Holiday Formation Framework

When family traditions, travel schedules, and holiday expectations hit, our underlying household scaffolding crumbles. To navigate the season with peace, we integrate four frameworks.

1 **HEART MIRROR**
Dan Allender

Recognize that a child's holiday meltdown is often a mirror exposing our own unhealed triggers, fears of judgment, and idols of control or image.

Ask: "What is my child exposing in ME?"

2 **PHASE WISDOM**
Daystar Counseling

Honor your child's emotional and neurological limits as schedules, diets, and environments shift.

Ask: "What does my child need in THIS season?"

3 **HOUSEHOLD LITURGIES**
Justin Whitmel Earley

Protect ordinary, repeatable rhythms of prayer, mealtime, and rest that form our hearts in the gospel.

Ask: "What spiritual anchors do we protect?"

4 **HABIT MECHANICS**
James Clear

Use habit stacking, environmental design, and micro-steps to lower friction for peace and increase friction for chaos.

Ask: "How do we practically execute this?"

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Each phase handout applies these four frameworks to a specific age group. Start with the question that matches your home this season, then turn to your child's phase.

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PART ONE

The Infant King & the Adult Soul

Re-centering our heart posture in the gospel story

Before we can regulate our children or lead our homes, we must steward our own souls. The holidays act as a psychological time machine, transporting adult hearts directly back into childhood dynamics, old insecurities, and the exhausting drive to perform.

When we turn back to the original Christmas story, the Gospels present a vastly different invitation. In his book *The Characters of Christmas*, Daniel Darling highlights how each figure played a distinct role, yet all were drawn by the same holy pull: **to see, worship, serve, and ultimately tell of the infant King.**

THE SHEPHERDS

Exhausted, working on the margins, and unexpected recipients of divine grace.

THE WISE MEN

Seekers carrying significant weight and responsibility, choosing to bow before something far greater than worldly stature.

MARY & JOSEPH

Navigating disruption, unexpected plans, and physical exhaustion while faithfully holding space for the presence of Christ.

THE HOST / INNKEEPER

Offering whatever humble, imperfect space was available without worrying about pristine presentation.

When our primary focus returns to Jesus, it offers a perspective that allows ancillary and worldly pressures to naturally fade into the background.

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PART ONE

Internal Stewardship for Parents & Adults

Parents and adults need the same care we ask of our children. These three practices address the heart patterns that the holidays expose most often.

1. UNMASKING THE IDOL OF HOLIDAY PERFECTIONISM

ALLENDER

The reality: We often treat the holidays as an evaluation of our worth, striving for the pristine meal, the perfectly behaved child, or the ideal gift. Allender reminds us that perfectionism is a defense mechanism built to protect us from shame and exposure.

Gospel focus: Shift from performance to presence. God does not demand a curated holiday. He offers a cozy, imperfect space filled with His grace. Your value is anchored as an image-bearer (*Imago Dei*), separate from your host duties, budget, or family approval.

2. DIFFUSING TRIGGERED PAIN & FAMILY REGRESSION

DAYSTAR & ALLENDER

The reality: Stepping back into childhood homes or extended family dynamics re-awakens ancient roles: the peacekeeper, the fixer, the dynamic offender. When an extended family member makes a sharp comment, our nervous system reacts as if we are ten years old again.

Practical action: the Self-Regulation Pause. When you feel your body tense up (racing heart, tight jaw), step outside or into a quiet bathroom. Take three deep breaths and speak truth to your heart: *"I am an adult anchored in Christ's love. I am safe, I am accepted, and I do not need to win this argument or carry their dysregulation."*

3. CURING THE "COURT OF PUBLIC OPINION"

EARLEY & CLEAR

The reality: Worrying about what in-laws, relatives, or social media followers think creates severe internal hurry and reactivity.

The micro-liturgy: the Daily Solitude Anchor (Clear's 2-Minute Rule). Before checking your phone or engaging with guests each morning, spend two minutes in silence with an open-palmed prayer: *"Lord, I surrender my need for approval today. Like the shepherds and wise men, I choose to fix my eyes on You, receive Your love, and offer Your peace."*

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PART TWO

Our Core Commitments

Honor, connect, communicate

To truly **thrive** this holiday season rather than merely survive it, we commit to three intentional postures rooted in Christ. Use these as the household's shared standard as the season unfolds.

1

CHOOSING TO HONOR HIM

We align our time, financial resources, and family schedule to honor Christ first, protecting our calendar from noise and performance anxiety.

2

CONNECTING INTENTIONALLY

We set aside deliberate time to connect with Jesus daily so we remain rooted in the real purpose of our faith and the holidays.

3

COMMUNICATING HIS LOVE

We share His life-changing love with our children and extended family, with a hurting world, with those walking through grief, and with guests in our homes.

MAKE IT VISIBLE AT HOME

Choose one practical action for each commitment this week, such as a shared dinner-table prayer for Honor, a daily two-minute quiet time for Connect, or inviting one guest to a holiday meal for Communicate. Post them where the family will see them.

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PART TWO

Protecting Marriage in the Holiday Storm

Covenant friendship, mutual submission, and gospel service. Grounded in Timothy & Kathy Keller's The Meaning of Marriage

The holidays subject marriages to intense pressure: debating family obligations, managing financial stretch, and navigating extended family expectations. Timothy and Kathy Keller remind us that Christian marriage is a gospel-reflecting covenant intended to foster holiness, deep friendship, and radical self-giving service rather than consumer self-fulfillment.

1. OVERCOMING CONSUMER MARRIAGE & SELF-CENTEREDNESS

KELLER & ALLENDER

The reality: Keller observes that modern culture views marriage as consumerist ("What is my spouse doing for me?"). During holiday exhaustion, spouses default to self-centeredness: tracking who worked harder, who got a break, or who is handling the domestic load.

Gospel alignment: True covenant love requires covenantal service. Jesus came not to be served, but to serve. Replace the scorekeeping posture ("You haven't helped me with hosting") with a Christ-like posture ("How can I love and serve you through this holiday strain?").

2. COVENANT LOYALTY OVER EXTENDED FAMILY DEMANDS

KELLER & ALLENDER

The reality: Holiday friction often reveals unsevered emotional ties to parents or family traditions. When a spouse feels thrown under the bus to appease an in-law, the primary covenant bond is compromised.

Gospel alignment: Keller emphasizes the Genesis mandate: "leave and cleave." Marriage creates a brand-new primary covenant unit that supersedes family-of-origin expectations.

Practical action: Present a unified front before entering family gatherings. Agree on visit lengths, budget limits, and boundaries in advance: *"We are on the same team. My spouse's emotional safety comes before pleasing my extended family."*

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PART TWO

Protecting Marriage in the Holiday Storm

3. PRACTICING “TRUTH IN GRACE” & GOSPEL FORGIVENESS

KELLER & DAYSTAR

The reality: Exhaustion lowers emotional bandwidth, leading to sharp words, passive aggression, or cold isolation between spouses.

Gospel alignment: Keller notes that marriage requires seeing the worst in each other yet covering it in grace, reflecting how Christ treats us.

Practical action: Speak “truth in grace” when hurt. Use pre-planned phrase anchors: *“I feel overwhelmed right now, but I love you and I want us to tackle this together.”* Forgive quickly, recognizing that both partners are operating under holiday strain.

4. THE 15-MINUTE COVENANT DEBRIEF & PRAYER LITURGY

KELLER, EARLEY & CLEAR

The reality: In the noise of holiday logistics, spouses easily descend into operational roommates.

The micro-liturgy (habit stack): Establish a non-negotiable 15-minute nightly marriage debrief. *“After the kids lie down for the night, we sit together without screens for 15 minutes.”*

The rhythm: Keller highlights spiritual intimacy as the core driver of deep friendship. Use Earley’s core relational check-ins:

- “Where did you feel stressed or hurt today?”
- “How can I serve or support you tomorrow?”
- “How can we pray for each other right now?”

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PHASE ONE | PRESCHOOL / PRE-K

Early Childhood

AGES 3-4½

Thriving the Holidays: a practical guide for this season.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Commander. Loving, steady authority providing a safe perimeter of routines amid holiday chaos.

THIS SEASON

Explosive imagination and rapid neurological growth, combined with undeveloped executive function, make big family gatherings, noisy rooms, and late nights deeply overwhelming. Parents stand as steady, protective anchors, pointing weary little hearts to the physical security of God's love.

DEVELOPMENTAL & HOLIDAY MILESTONES

01

NEUROLOGICAL

Easily overwhelmed by sensory noise, gift clutter, and schedule shifts. Self-control is still developing.

02

PHYSICAL & EMOTIONAL

Prone to emotional crashes after big events. Holiday travel can trigger temporary sleep disruptions or night fears.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1. **Honor Through Story, Song & Micro-Liturgies.** Teach small children to honor Christ through story and song. When travel disrupts the routine, protect a 2-minute morning and bedtime anchor (a quiet verse, a Christmas carol, a hug, and a blessing) to signal safety to their nervous system.

2. **Move from Contempt to Curiosity.** When a meltdown happens at a relative's house, pause before reacting. Ask yourself: "Is my anger about their emotional fatigue, or my embarrassment before extended family?" Step into a private room to soothe rather than forcing public compliance.

3. **Comfort Fears with Gospel Presence.** New holiday environments often trigger separation anxiety or night terrors. Do not lecture or reason. Sit with them, pray aloud, and remind them that "God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and a sound mind" (2 Timothy 1:7).

THE RULE

Strictly Limited & Contextualized

Screen considerations: under age 6, non-educational screen time should be less than 1 hour per weekday, and that limit holds during the holiday break. Never use devices as holiday "pacifiers" during long dinners, errands, or tantrums. Keep attention on real-world play, physical crafts, and sensory breaks away from crowds.

FOR YOU THIS SEASON: THE ADULT ANCHOR

"Lord, I surrender my need for approval today. Like the shepherds and wise men, I choose to fix my eyes on You, receive Your love, and offer Your peace."

Spend two quiet minutes with this prayer before checking your phone or greeting guests. Your steadiness is what your child borrows when the house gets loud.

SPECIAL CONSIDERATIONS FOR THE SEASON

HONOR YOUR CAPACITY

Give yourself permission to step back from non-essential traditions or social obligations without guilt.

BRING YOUR PAIN TO HIM

For many, the holidays amplify the silence of an empty chair. Jesus is not intimidated by our tears, and He draws near to the brokenhearted.

EMBRACE "BOTH/AND"

We can miss loved ones who have gone before us and still enjoy the laughs, food, and connection with those who are with us.

PLAN AHEAD WITH RELATIVES

Share nap schedules, gift guidelines, and dietary needs with family days before the gathering. Agree on visit length and an exit plan as a team.

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

Call Peak Wellness Centers at **865.643.8838**. For urgent concerns at any hour, call or text **988**, the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline.

BUILT ON

Dan Allender, *The Heart of Parenting* | Daystar Counseling Ministries, Phase Wisdom | Justin Whitmel Earley, *Habits of the Household* | James Clear, *Atomic Habits* | Timothy & Kathy Keller, *The Meaning of Marriage*

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PHASE TWO | KINDERGARTEN - 2ND GRADE

Middle Childhood

AGES 5-7

Thriving the Holidays: a practical guide for this season.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Coach. Standing on the sidelines to guide, encourage, and prompt grace and sportsmanship during holiday play.

THIS SEASON

Transitioning into school environments brings an intense battle with perfectionism, competitive pouting, and boundary-testing. Holiday gift-giving and board games amplify these dynamics, providing a rich training ground to coach humility, honesty, and grace under pressure.

DEVELOPMENTAL & HOLIDAY MILESTONES

01

NEUROLOGICAL

Attention span grows. Highly sensitive to criticism or to feeling like they lost while opening gifts or playing with cousins.

02

SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Prone to perfectionism (“age 7 melancholy”) and late-day holiday emotional crashes.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1. **Coach Gratitude & Defeat.** Before opening presents or playing family games, roleplay how to receive gifts graciously and handle losing with character. Say: “In this family, we honor God by being grateful for every kindness and celebrating others.”

2. **Use Liturgy Stacking in Car Transitions.** Attach a heart-alignment habit to travel: “After we pull into Grandma’s driveway, we will pause for 30 seconds in the car to pray for kind words and a servant’s heart.”

3. **Expose the Idol of Image.** If your child acts ungratefully in front of relatives, notice your own chest tightening. Address your desire for a “picture-perfect child” privately with God before gently guiding your child’s heart.

THE RULE

Entertainment Caps & Content Control

The action: maintain a firm 2-hour daily maximum for holiday movies or games. Keep family meal tables and bedrooms strictly screen-free to prioritize face-to-face connection.

FOR YOU THIS SEASON: THE ADULT ANCHOR

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PHASE THREE | 3RD - 5TH GRADE

Pre-Adolescence

AGES 8-10

Thriving the Holidays: a practical guide for this season.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Captain. Protecting relational equity with your pre-teen amid peer comparison and holiday material pressures.

THIS SEASON

As the focal point of their world shifts toward peers, holiday wish lists and gift comparisons can fuel anxiety and entitlement. Parents must protect connection, coaching pre-teens to anchor their worth securely in Christ rather than cultural trends.

DEVELOPMENTAL & HOLIDAY MILESTONES

01

NEUROLOGICAL & PHYSICAL

Abstract thinking begins. Holiday anxiety often shows up physically as tummy aches or headaches before large social events.

02

SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Highly influenced by peer dynamics and trends. Prone to hiding internal anxieties behind silence or moody withdrawal.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1. **Protect the 30-Minute Holiday Connection.** In the middle of busy family schedules, secure 30 minutes of dedicated, one-on-one time where your child chooses the activity.
2. **Engage in Servant Liturgies.** Shift focus away from personal wish lists by involving them directly in serving local ministries, packaging neighbor gifts, or helping host guests.
3. **Address Somatic Holiday Stress.** When stomach aches appear before big family gatherings, practice deep breathing and quote scripture together. Remind them: “Your worth is anchored in Jesus, not in what anyone thinks of you today.”

THE RULE

No Personal Smartphones as Christmas Gifts

The action: resist the network effect pressure to gift smartphones during the holidays. Stick to non-connected devices or basic alternatives to protect real-world social mastery and mental health.

FOR YOU THIS SEASON: THE ADULT ANCHOR

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PHASE FOUR | 6TH - 7TH GRADE

Early Adolescence

AGES 11-12

Thriving the Holidays: a practical guide for this season.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Counselor. Trading lectures and top-down control for active listening, private guidance, and dignity.

THIS SEASON

The onset of puberty, shifting sleep needs, and extreme self-consciousness make long family gatherings exhausting for early adolescents. Parents must prioritize relationship preservation, private correction, and guided choices over public battles.

DEVELOPMENTAL & HOLIDAY MILESTONES

01

NEUROLOGICAL & PHYSICAL

Heavy brain remodeling. Sleep cycles shift naturally, so they may want to stay up late and sleep in. Highly prone to social fatigue.

02

SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Moody, easily frustrated, and intensely self-conscious around extended family and peers.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1. **Never Correct in Public.** Due to strong social self-consciousness, public discipline during holiday events breeds deep resentment. Wait until you are alone in the car or bedroom to address disrespect.
2. **Give Guided Autonomy Over Schedules.** Avoid authoritarian control. Offer choices that lower the friction for conflict: “We have two family events today. How would you like to structure your downtime so you feel rested?”
3. **Listen and Don’t “Fix.”** When they vent about family drama or holiday pressure, listen without immediately stepping in as judge or fixer. Be a steady, non-anxious processing partner.

THE RULE

No Social Media & Central Nighttime Charging

The action: protect early adolescents from social comparison algorithms during holiday breaks. Keep holiday gatherings phone-free ("bell-to-bell") and require all devices to charge in a central room at night.

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PHASE FIVE | 9TH GRADE & BEYOND

High School & Adulthood

AGES 13-18+

Thriving the Holidays: a practical guide for this season.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Consultant. Moving from direct authority to an on-call advisor, respecting their independence and modeling gospel rest.

THIS SEASON

High schoolers often enter holiday breaks suffering from academic burnout and future-oriented anxiety. As they evaluate their identity and faith, parents must step into the passenger seat, offering margin, rest, and authentic gospel grace.

DEVELOPMENTAL & HOLIDAY MILESTONES

01

NEUROLOGICAL & PHYSICAL

Advanced reasoning capabilities, along with significant fatigue from academic and performance pressures.

02

SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Establishing a distinct adult identity and evaluating personal beliefs and spiritual values.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1. **Model Intentionality & Gospel Rest.** Teens learn more from what we model than what we preach. Prioritize spiritual rest over academic or social burnout, showing that human worth comes from being an image-bearer (*Imago Dei*) rather than constant hustle.

2. **Connect Through Authentic Dialogue.** Create safe spaces for older youth to express honest questions, doubts, or holiday fatigue without meeting them with defensive anger.

3. **Communicate Purpose & Time Budgets.** Encourage them to design a holiday “time budget” that includes dedicated digital fasts to cultivate quiet presence with God and family.

THE RULE

Time Budgets & Digital Fasts

The action: invite teens to plan their own holiday time budget, with set blocks for digital fasts. Keep the focus on quiet presence with God and family rather than policing every screen.

FOR YOU THIS SEASON: THE ADULT ANCHOR

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EMBRACE "BOTH/AND"

We can miss loved ones who have gone before us and still enjoy the laughs, food, and connection with those who are with us.

PLAN AHEAD WITH RELATIVES

Give teens a voice in holiday plans, including how long they stay and when they need downtime. Agree on the plan as a family before the gathering.

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

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PART THREE

Special Considerations for the Season

Grief, loss, and family expectations

CONNECTING AMID GRIEF & LOSS

For many, the holidays amplify the silence of an empty chair at the dinner table.

HONOR YOUR CAPACITY

Give yourself permission to step back from non-essential traditions or social obligations without guilt.

CONNECT WITH THE "MAN OF SORROWS"

Jesus is not intimidated by our tears. Bring your pain directly to Him, knowing He draws near to the brokenhearted. David was very honest and open with God in the Psalms, a great model for our relationship with Him.

EMBRACE "BOTH/AND"

We can miss our loved ones who have gone before us and enjoy the laughs, smiles, food, and connection with our loved ones who are with us. One does not have to negate the other.

COMMUNICATE NEEDS

Express your emotional limits clearly to family members beforehand. For example: *"We are looking forward to coming, but we may need to leave early."*

COMMUNICATING FAMILY EXPECTATIONS TO MINIMIZE CONFLICT

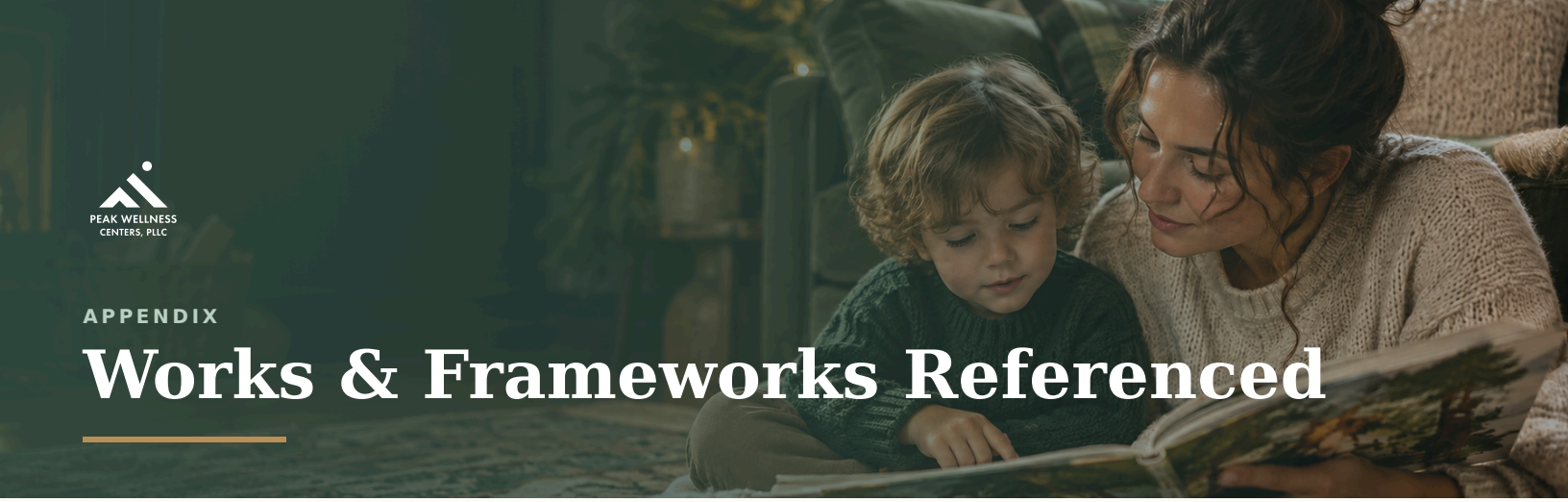
To prevent misunderstanding and emotional friction with immediate and extended family:

PRE-EVENT HUDDLES

Before entering large family gatherings, agree on visit durations, budget boundaries, and exit strategies as a unified team.

PROACTIVE CLARITY

Share gift guidelines, nap schedules, or dietary needs with relatives days before events so everyone is set up for success.



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APPENDIX

Works & Frameworks Referenced

To assist parents, leaders, and counselors who wish to dive deeper into the clinical, psychological, and spiritual foundations in this guide, these are the key sources.

1 **Dan Allender, Ph.D.**
The Heart of Parenting: How Your Past Shapes Your Child's Future & *To Be Told: Know Your Story, Shape Your Future*
Contribution: Exposing parent and adult triggers, performance anxiety, perfectionism as a defense mechanism, and moving from contempt to curiosity.

2 **Daystar Counseling Ministries**
Sissy Goff, M.Ed., LPC-MHSP & David Thomas, LMSW. *Raising Worry-Free Girls*, *Are My Kids on Track?*, & Daystar Phase Wisdom
Contribution: Emotional development, neurological limits across stages, handling somatic stress, non-public correction, and relational equity.

3 **Justin Whitmel Earley**
The Tech-Wise Family & *Habits of the Household: Practicing the Story of God in Everyday Family Rhythms*
Contribution: Household liturgies, non-negotiable spiritual anchors, device-free family boundaries, and bedtime and mealtime micro-liturgies.

4 **James Clear**
Atomic Habits: An Easy & Proven Way to Build Good Habits & Break Bad Ones
Contribution: Habit mechanics, environmental design, habit stacking, friction manipulation, and the 2-Minute Rule.

5 **Timothy & Kathy Keller**
The Meaning of Marriage: Facing the Complexities of Commitment with the Wisdom of God
Contribution: Covenant loyalty over extended family demands, overcoming consumer mindsets, practicing "truth in grace," and spiritual intimacy rhythms.

6 **Daniel Darling**
The Characters of Christmas: 10 Unlikely People Who Attended the First Christmas
Contribution: Theological foundation examining the diverse Gospel figures (shepherds, wise men, Mary and Joseph, the innkeeper) and re-centering Christmas on Jesus.